

Session 11: Parting of the Brothers

Key Takeaways

- The separation of Yaaqov and Esau resounds with notes of the Cain and Abel theme, but with many inversions and surprises.
- Rivqah indeed receives the curse for her scheming with Yaaqov when she says goodbye to her beloved son, never to see him again.
- Esau, in his anger, is set on analogy to both Cain and God, presenting a complex portrait of Yaaqov's adversary.

Esau's Anger and Yaaqov's Flight

41 And Esau was opposed to Yaaqov,
on account of the **blessing** with which his father **blessed** him,
and Esau said in his heart,

“The days of mourning for my father draw near,
and **I will murder Yaaqov my brother.**”

42 And it was reported to Rivqah, the words of **Esau her son, the greater one**,
and she sent and called for **Yaaqov her son, the smaller one**,
and she said to him,

“Look, **Esau your brother** is comforting himself about you, **to murder you!**

43 So now, my son, listen to my voice,
and arise, flee for yourself to **Lavan**, my brother, to **Haran**.

44 And you will dwell with him one set of days,
until **the hot-anger of your brother turns away**,

45 until **the anger of your brother turns away from you**,
and he forgets what you have done to him,
and I will send and take you from there.

Why should I be bereaved of the two of you in one day?!”

Genesis 27:41-45. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Esau, Cain, and the Flood-Sending God

In Genesis 27:41, Esau is set on analogy with Cain who is angry at God's favor on his brother, and also with God who responds to human evil by sending the flood.

Esau in Genesis 27

Gen. 27:34 and [Esau] **cried out a great cry** (ויצעק צעקה)

Gen. 27:41 And Esau held a grudge against Yaaqov ... and **he said in his heart** (בלבו + אמר), "The days of **mourning** (אבל / הבל) are near, and I will **murder Yaaqov my brother** (אחי + הרג)."

Gen. 27:42 Behold, Esau **your brother is consoling himself** (נחם) regarding you, **to murder you** (הרג).

Cain & Abel in Genesis 4

Gen. 4:8 And Qayin spoke to **Hevel (הבל) his brother**, and it came about when they were in the field that Qayin rose up to Hevel **his brother and he murdered him** (הרג + אח).

Gen. 4:10 What have you done? The voice of the shed-blood of your brother is **crying out** (צעק) to me from the ground.

Yahweh in Genesis 6

Gen. 6:5-13 And Yahweh saw that multiplied was the badness of humanity in the land, and every purpose of the plans of **his heart** (לבו) was only bad all the day, and Yahweh **consolated himself** (נחם) that he made humanity in the land, and he was pained **in his heart** (לבו). And Yahweh said, "I will wipe away humanity that I created from the face of the ground, from humanity to animals to creeping things and to birds of the skies, for **I console myself** (נחם) that I have made them. ..."

And Elohim said to Noakh, "**The end** (קץ) of all flesh has **come before me**, because the land is filled with violence because of them, and behold, I am going to ruin them with land."

Gen. 8:21 And Yahweh smelled the soothing smell; and Yahweh **said to his heart** (לבו), "I will never again curse the ground on account of humanity, because the purpose of the heart of humanity is bad from his youth; and I will never again strike all life, as I just did."

Esau, Cain, and the Flood-Sending God. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The Analogies

Just as non-chosen Cain was angry and spilled the blood of his chosen brother Abel, murdering him, and his blood cried out to God, so now the non-chosen Esau is angry so he cries out and wants to murder his chosen brothers.

Just as God had to console himself and speak in his heart for making a humanity whose violence created "the end" that has come up before him, so now Esau cries out and plans to console himself by murdering his treacherous brother.

The Point of the Analogies

The narrative strategy portrays Rivqah and Yitskhaq’s deceptive grab for the blessing as an act akin to Adam and Eve’s failure to trust God’s command in the garden.

Now we’ve come to the next generation. And just as Cain failed to honor God’s choice of Abel, so now Esau fails to honor God’s choice of Yaaqov (though Yaaqov hardly deserves it). This causes an outbreak of violence that leads to righteous anger and a threat to life itself.

Genesis 2 • God’s blessing of fruitful seed • Garden abundance in the midst of a desert • Sacred space of God’s presence by the tree of life on Mount Eden	Genesis 3 • Wife and husband are deceived • Violation of God’s word • Attempt to achieve the blessing in the wrong time and way	Genesis 4-9 • Sibling rivalry, angry brother murders brother, the blood cries out • Inappropriate taking of wives from the wrong lineage • The outcry comes up to God who speaks in his heart, consoles himself and decides to send the flood • So God chooses to send his chosen one away to safety, Noah	Genesis 10-11 • A journey east • A tower in the skies • Scattering of Babylon
Genesis 26 • God’s blessing on Yitskhaq, abundant food and water in the midst of a famine • Yitskhaq worships Yahweh by tent and altar at Well of Seven	Genesis 27:1-29 • Deception between wife and husband • Violation of God’s word • Struggle to achieve the blessing in the wrong time and way	Genesis 27:30-28:9 • Sibling rivalry, angry brother cries out, speaks in his heart to console himself and murder his brother • Inappropriate taking of wives from the wrong lineage • The plan reaches Yaaqov’s mother who plans to send him away to safety	Genesis 28:10-22 • A journey east • A tower in the skies

Replaying the Earlier Genesis Cycle in Genesis 26-28. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Taking the Wrong Wives

⁴⁶ And Rivqah said to Yitskhaq,
“I hate **my life**, because of **the Hittite daughters**.
If Yaaqov took a wife from daughters of the Hittites like these,
from **the daughters of the land**,
why then should **I live**?!”

28:1 And Yitskhaq called to Yaaqov,

and he **blessed** him

and he commanded him,

and he said to him,

"You will not take a wife from the daughters of Canaan .

² Arise, **go to Paddan-aram ,**

to the house of Bethuel , the father of your mother,

and **take for yourself from there a wife,**

from the daughters of Lavan , brother of your mother.

³ And El-Shadday, **may he bless you,**

and may he make your fruitful

and may he bless you

and may you become an assembly of peoples,

⁴ **and may he give to you the blessing of Abraham ,**

to you and to your **seed** with you,

so you can possess the **land** of your migrations

which Elohim has given to **Abraham .**

⁵ And Yitskhaq sent Yaaqov away,

and he went to **Paddan-aram ,**

to **Lavan ,** son of **Bethuel** the Aramean,

brother of Rivqah, mother of Yaaqov and Esau.

⁶ **And Esau saw**

that Yitskhaq had **blessed** Yaaqov,

and that he sent him to **Paddan-aram ,**

to take for himself a wife from there,

when he **blessed** him,

and that he commanded him, saying,

"You will not take a wife from the daughters of Canaan ,"

⁷ and that Yaaqov listened to his father and to his mother,

and that he went to **Paddan-aram .**

⁸ **And Esau saw**

that **the daughters of Canaan** were bad in the eyes of Yitskhaq his father,

⁹ **and Esau went** to Yishmael,

and he took Makhelath,

daughter of Yishmael ,

son of Abraham,

sister of Nebaioth,

in addition to his wives,

for himself as a wife.

The analogy with the flood narrative continues as the theme of marriage enters the picture. The shift from Esau's plan to murder Yaaqov to Rivqah's plan to send away Yaaqov seems abrupt. But the narrative sequence makes more sense once we see that we're walking through the themes of Genesis 1-9 in order.

Just as illegitimate marriages between Heaven and Earth were the third and final failure narrative in Genesis 1-9, so here the focus is on Esau's illegitimate marriages to Canaanite women that threaten the integrity of the promised lineage.

Genesis 6:1-2 Instructor's Translation

¹ And it came about, when humanity began to multiply on the face of the land, and daughters were born to/for them, ² **and the sons of Elohim saw the daughters of humanity that they were good**, **and they took wives for themselves**, whomever they chose.

Genesis 28:8-9 Instructor's Translation

⁸ **And Esau saw that the daughters of Canaan were bad** in the eyes of Yitskhaq his father, ⁹ and Esau went to Yishmael, and **he took** Makhelath, daughter of Yishmael, **for himself as a wife**.

There is also an ironic inversion of the Abraham story at this point: Rivqah, who left Mesopotamia in a great act of trust that resembled Abraham, now sends away her son to Mesopotamia because of her lack of trust in God's promise of blessing.

Abraham, Yitskhaq and Rivqah: Genesis 24	Yitskhaq, Rivqah, and Yaaqov: Genesis 28
Abraham does not want Yitskhaq to marry the Canaanites and sends his servant to Mesopotamia to his extended family Gen. 24:3-4 so I can make you swear an oath by Yahweh, the Elohim of the skies and the Elohim of the land, that you will not take a wife for my son from the daughters of the Canaanites , in whose midst I am dwelling. Rather, to my land and to my family you will go , and you will take a wife for my son , for Yitskhaq."	Yitskhaq and Rivqah do not want Yaaqov to marry the Canaanites, and they send Yaaqov to Mesopotamia to their extended family Gen. 28:1-2 You will not take a wife from the daughters of Canaan . Get up, go to Paddan-aram, to the house of Bethuel, the father of your mother , and take for yourself from there a wife .
Abraham's servant meets Rivqah, who waters the animals, at a well	Yaaqov goes, meets Rakhel at a well, and he waters the animals
Abraham's servant meets Lavan	Yaaqov meets Lavan
Comparing Genesis 24 and 28. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Reflection Question

Why would the biblical authors connect Esau's anger to God's own anger over the outcry before the flood?



Module 3: Jacob's Exile

SESSIONS 12-16

Jacob travels far away to find a wife among his mother's family. Will he learn to trust in God's promises or continue to scheme to find blessing?